Intelligence and Communications Technologies mulled how America and other countries should manage their security and intelligence agencies in the digital age (some of its recommendations were sensible, others in my view unworkable or dangerous). President Obama on January 17th announced some modest and largely cosmetic changes to the NSA's remit, but has broadly endorsed its activities and approach.[6]

Ultimately, voters will have their say, in America and in other democracies too. But it does not seem that voters wish to destroy current intelligence capabilities, or to rewrite the statute book to make privacy inviolable always and everywhere, and at whatever cost, as some Snowdenistas seemingly want.

Despite sensationalist, ill-informed and sometimes misleading commentary in much of the media, public opinion in Britain and America seems broadly to agree with the proposition that releasing state secrets damages national security. In Britain, for example, 42% of those asked in a poll last year thought the security services had broadly the right powers; a further 22% thought they should have more.[7]

The NSA and associated organisations are huge. Distinguishing the communications of terrorists and other adversaries from the innocent data of innocent Americans is tricky. Things do go wrong. In the 'LOVEINT' scandal a small number of NSA officials were found to have abused their position to snoop on people of interest in their private lives. They were disciplined. I think they should have been fired and prosecuted. Corrupt, self-interested intelligence officers are as big a threat to our freedom, or even a bigger one, as corrupt, self-interested police or judges. Their numbers may be tiny, but that is no reason for complacency.

Leaving aside wilful individual wrongdoing, it is clear that the NSA has also over-reached. Since 2011 some 56,000 e-mails of 'US persons' have been improperly read, a judgment from the FISA court reveals.